

SHOGI · VARIANT 40 OF 24

Tori Shogi

7×7
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

TORI SHOGI

Tori Shogi (トリスゴ, “Bird Shogi”) is a Shogi variant invented by Toyota Genryu in 1799, traditionally attributed to his master Ohashi Soei. Played on a 7×7 board with a bird-themed piece set, Tori Shogi has sustained popularity, English-language books, and active tournaments. It is one of the oldest Shogi variants to use the drop rule. The goal is to checkmate the opposing **Phoenix** (the royal piece).

SETUP

Board: 7 files (a–g) × 7 ranks.

Pieces per player: 16 — 1 Phoenix, 1 Left Quail, 1 Right Quail, 2 Cranes, 2 Pheasants, 1 Falcon, 8 Swallows.

Starting position:

RANK	CONTENTS
Rank 1 — Gote back	Right Quail(a) · Pheasant(b) · Crane© · Phoenix(d) · Crane(e) · Pheasant(f) · Left Quail(g)
Rank 2 — Gote	... Falcon(d) ...
Rank 3 — Gote Swallows	Swallow × 7 (all files)
Rank 4 — Advanced	Gote Swallow© ... Sente Swallow(e)
Rank 5 — Sente Swallows	Swallow × 7 (all files)
Rank 6 — Sente	... Falcon(d) ...
Rank 7 — Sente back	Left Quail(a) · Pheasant(b) · Crane© · Phoenix(d) · Crane(e) · Pheasant(f) · Right Quail(g)

Each side’s 8 Swallows: 7 on their home Swallow rank + 1 advanced to rank 4. Gote moves first.

SFEN: rpckcpl/3f3/sssssss/2s1S2/SSSSSSS/3F3/LPCKCPR[-] w 0 1

(Piece letter assignments — r/R = Right Quail, l/L = Left Quail, p/P = Pheasant, c/C = Crane, k/K = Phoenix (royal), f/F = Falcon, s/S = Swallow. Empty hand at start: [-].)

PIECES

PIECE	SYMBOL	MOVEMENT
Phoenix	K	One step in any of the 8 directions. Royal piece.
Crane	C	One step in any direction except left or right (six directions: forward, backward, four diagonals).
Pheasant	P	One step diagonally backward (two diagonal directions), OR jumps two squares straight forward (cannot be blocked).
Left Quail	L	Slides any number of squares straight forward; slides any number of squares diagonally right-backward; one step diagonally left-backward.
Right Quail	R	Mirror of Left Quail: slides forward; slides diagonally left-backward; one step diagonally right-backward.
Falcon	F	One step in any of the 8 directions except straight backward (seven directions). Promotes to Eagle .
Swallow	S	One step directly forward. Promotes to Goose .
Goose (+S)	+S	Jumps exactly two squares diagonally forward (either direction), OR exactly two squares straight backward. Cannot be blocked.
Eagle (+F)	+F	Slides any number of squares diagonally forward or straight backward; one step in any direction; up to two squares diagonally backward (not a jump; can be blocked). Strongest piece in the game.

Only the Swallow and Falcon promote. Phoenix, Cranes, Pheasants, and Quails never promote.

RULES

Drops: Captured pieces go to the capturing player's hand and may be dropped on any empty square on a later turn, with the following restrictions specific to Swallows:

- ♦ A Swallow may not be dropped to give immediate checkmate.
- ♦ A Swallow may not be dropped on a file that already contains **two** friendly Swallows.
- ♦ A Swallow may not be dropped on the last rank (rank 1 for Gote, rank 7 for Sente).

Promotion zone: the last two ranks (ranks 6–7 for Sente). Promotion is compulsory when a Swallow or Falcon reaches the promotion zone.

Repetition: If the same position occurs three times with the same player to move and the same pieces in hand, the player who **caused** the repetition loses. This is the reverse of the standard Shogi draw rule.

Perpetual check is likewise a loss for the player causing it.

Stalemate: A player with no legal move loses.

WIN CONDITIONS

Checkmate the opponent's Phoenix — attack it such that no legal move can escape. A player with no legal move loses.

ATTRIBUTION

Tori Shogi was invented by Toyota Genryu (1799). Public domain. Rules documented from pychess.org/variants/torishogi.